

Residents wax protective over the Triangle's trees

By LISA BELLAMY
Staff writer

A tree falling in a forest might go unheeded. But a tree being cut or pruned in the city is never unnoticed.

Just look at what happened in Raleigh when crews started cutting down 50-year-old oak trees to make room for construction at Cameron Village Shopping Center. City offices were bombarded with calls.

"My boyfriend was really livid," says Melissa Weedy, who grew up on a farm in Ohio and lives near the shopping center.

"He said those trees belong to the people. They don't have any right to tear them down."

The same thing has happened over and over around the Triangle — in Chapel Hill when U.S. 15-501 was widened and trees were cut, in Durham when Club Boulevard was widened and 14 oaks were axed and in Cary when the expansion of a mall threatened a mighty oak.

Any time large trees are removed, trimmed or otherwise tampered with, people complain.

"They just don't like it," says Andy Gilliam, Raleigh's urban forester. "Peo-

ple feel like trees are part of the community, part of their heritage. They've grown up with those trees. A tree that old and that large is irreplaceable, and people know that."

Trees are a big part of the Triangle's image. Raleigh calls itself the City of Oaks. Hillsborough is Tree City USA. Area neighborhoods have names like Greenwood Acres and Forest Hills. Homes in older in-town neighborhoods, shaded by massive trees, are sought-after.

When that wooded character is threatened by chain saws, the people speak out.

Sometimes they save the trees, some times not.

The folks in Durham's Forest Hills neighborhood managed to stop the widening of University Drive, which would have brought heavy traffic and taken the towering oaks that line the street.

"To take those down changes the way the neighborhood looks," says Forest Hills resident John Hodges Copple. "And, of course, you get a little sapling out front, but it takes 50 years for it to grow."

Concern for the fate of a massive red oak at Cary Towne Center persuaded

mall management to spare it during renovation. Management has spent thousands of dollars to preserve the old farm tree, atop a fenced hill between Hecht's and Dillard's. But some tree experts say it eventually will have to be cut anyway.

Objects of worship

The human preoccupation with trees dates back at least to the days of the Druids, who worshipped them, says Thomas Perry, retired professor of forestry.

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Yearning to fly



Volunteer Rob McKenzie shows off one of the Carolina Raptor Center's draws, a Swainson's hawk

Staff photo by Scott Sharpe

Carolina Raptor Center soaring to the assistance of birds of prey

By MARTHA QUILLIN
Staff writer

CHARLOTTE — Like the hundreds of birds it has nursed to health and set free, the Carolina Raptor Center is taking off.

Twelve years after it was started by biology students at the University of North Carolina at Charlotte, the center will dedicate its first permanent quarters today, will open a new aviary and will extend its hours so the public can spend more time watching and learning about falcons, eagles, owls and other birds of prey.

"Our first priority is public education," says Patricia A. Marcum, executive director of the center, started in the basement of the biology building at UNCC. Now spread over 57 acres in a corner of Mecklenburg County's Latta Plantation Park north of Charlotte, the center is home to more than 20 species of raptors, from barred owls to bald eagles.

Serving also as a hospital and rehabilita-

Permanent home will be dedicated today

tion center, it is the largest facility in the Carolinas for the treatment of orphaned, sick and injured birds. In the past, the center has accepted birds from as far away as Pennsylvania and Florida.

It is a full-service center for raptors, with an intensive care unit for severely injured birds, outdoor "weathering" areas where the animals exercise and learn to fend for themselves, and a placement program that releases birds in areas where they are unlikely to survive.

Birds that can't be returned to the wild — those that can't fend for themselves — spend the rest of their lives at the Raptor Center, sharing airy cages with others of their species and participating in educational and breeding programs.

At any given time, there are 180 to 200 birds at the center, many of which are in display cages along a half-mile trail that winds through the north Mecklenburg County woods.

On weekdays, the center has been open in the past only for scheduled groups of school children, nursing home residents and others interested in learning about these wide-winged birds that soar out of sight of most North Carolina residents.

On weekends, the center was open to any visitors who wanted to walk the trail, pick up a brochure or catch a session with one of the center's gloved volunteers working with a bird.

Last year, Marcum says, at least 16,000 people came through, looked at the birds and listened to their shrill cries.

Beginning today, with the opening of the new 4,000-square-foot Moretti Environmental Education Center, visitors will be able to

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Duke closes in on detection of Alzheimer's

PET scan offers diagnosis hope

By RACHELE KANIGEL
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To doctors, Alzheimer's disease is like an invisible thief who pilfers memories, snatches words, steals the gold of life — but eludes detection.

The progressive disorder hides so deeply in the brain that doctors have been unable to positively diagnose it until after a patient has died.

Now researchers at Duke University say they may have found a way to identify the disease before it gets a stranglehold on patients.

The key is PET — Positron Emission Tomography — a technology that displays images of the brain in vibrant colors. Using PET, scientists can see on a computer screen how Alzheimer's ravages the brain, shutting down whole parts of the body's most complicated organ.

Researchers say PET by itself won't give doctors a definitive diagnosis. But when used with other diagnostic tools — a medical examination, blood tests and other scanning technology — it can help doctors determine whether a patient is on the downhill road to Alzheimer's disease.

"It's not a perfect test, nothing is," says Dr. John Hoffman, an assistant professor of neurology and radiology at Duke. "But if we add PET to numerous other tests, we think we may be able to make an earlier and more reliable diagnosis."

The research doesn't mean everyone with memory problems should get a PET scan. The technology is prohibitively expensive — about \$1,900 per evaluation — and currently there isn't much people can do once they learn they have Alzheimer's disease.

But researchers say PET is expected to play a vital role in understanding Alzheimer's disease and developing treatments.

"It may be very important in drug studies," said Dr. Kathleen Welsh, a neuropsychologist with the Joseph and Kathleen Bryan Alzheimer's Disease Research Center. "We want to get people in early, when drug intervention is most likely to help people."

Alzheimer's is a natural target for PET research because it continues to baffle scientists in so



The blue colors in this scan correspond to areas of brain activity, showing the dramatic changes Alzheimer's can cause

many ways. No one knows what causes it, how to treat it or how to stop its deadly progression.

What is known is that it's a growing problem. An estimated one in 10 people over 65 and nearly half of those over 85 are thought to have Alzheimer's disease. Today, that's about 4 million people. The National Institute on Aging predicts that as many as 14 million people will suffer from the disease by 2050.

Alzheimer's usually starts with memory problems — forgetting words, misplacing things, losing the souvenirs of the mind. Once the disease sets in, patients begin to lose reasoning, unique character traits and, finally, physical functioning. In the final stages, most patients are unable to dress themselves, feed themselves, even go to the bathroom.

Although there are no treatments for Alzheimer's disease, it is critical to diagnose the illness properly because other kinds of dementia can be treated. Currently, doctors diagnose the disease by a process of elimination, deciding on Alzheimer's when nothing else fits. The only sure diagnosis comes with an autopsy, when scientists can examine slices of the brain.

PET offers the next best thing. The scanned images show how radioactively tagged chemicals are distributed in the brain. In the Alzheimer's disease study, re-

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